

This is where your calendar shifts from things you *have* to do to things you *want* to do.

2. *Margin*. This refers to financial margin. You aren't living paycheck to paycheck, and no one else has a claim on your money. You are free to financially support the things you're passionate about or to respond to an emergency need without worrying about putting your family in a bind. You can give generously and quickly, because you know you can afford it.
3. *Options*. By options, I mean you've got the power to make choices. You aren't weighed down by financial obligations or calendar restrictions. Instead of feeling like you're under the thumb of an employer or a mortgage lender, you're taking control of your own decisions. The only one calling the shots on your time and money is you.
4. *Availability*. If you've been chained to a desk for most of your life, this is a game changer. Financial independence gives you the freedom to be there for people you care about. If an out-of-state friend calls with bad news, you can hop on a plane immediately without asking for anyone's permission. You can respond in an instant, because you have the time and money to be there for anyone, anywhere, anytime.

This kind of freedom changes you, inside and out.

But what about those who don't become financially independent at any point in their lives? What does life look like for them? To be blunt—it often doesn't look good. Vanguard reports that the average 401(k) balance in America is \$103,866.³⁶ That takes into account all age groups, from those under twenty-five to those over sixty-five. Obviously, younger folks are going to have less saved than their parents and grandparents, so let's just look at the over-sixty-five group. The average 401(k) balance in that group is \$209,984.³⁷ If that represents *all* of an average person's retirement savings, then they're in trouble. Using the industry standard 4% annual withdrawal, this person is looking at an annual retirement income of—wait for it—\$8,000. That's less than \$700 *per month*. Can you live on that now? I can't. Will that fund your high-definition retirement dream? It won't fund mine. And yet that's how more and more families are hitting their